

The Solar System consists of the Sun and the objects that orbit it, either directly or indirectly. Of those objects that orbit the Sun directly, the largest are the eight planets, with the remainder being smaller objects, such as dwarf planets and small Solar System bodies.

The inner Solar System contains the terrestrial planets Mercury, Venus, Earth, and Mars. These are primarily composed of rock and metal. The outer Solar System is made up of the gas giants Jupiter and Saturn, and the ice giants Uranus and Neptune. These four planets are substantially larger than the terrestrial planets.

The asteroid belt lies between Mars and Jupiter. It consists mainly of small bodies made of rock and metal. Beyond Neptune lies the Kuiper Belt, which is similar to the asteroid belt but far larger. It is composed mainly of icy bodies and dwarf planets such as Pluto.

Comets are small Solar System bodies composed largely of volatile ices. They have eccentric orbits, bringing them close to the Sun, where they develop tails of gas and dust. Some comets are short-period comets, originating from the Kuiper Belt, while others are long-period comets, coming from the more distant Oort Cloud.

The Sun is the star at the center of the Solar System. It is a nearly perfect sphere of hot plasma, radiating energy primarily through nuclear fusion of hydrogen into helium. This energy supports life on Earth and drives Earth's climate and weather.

Jupiter is the largest planet in the Solar System. It is a gas giant, primarily composed of hydrogen and helium. It has at least 79 moons, including Ganymede, the largest moon in the Solar System. Jupiter's Great Red Spot is a giant storm that has existed for centuries.

Saturn is best known for its extensive ring system, which is composed mainly of ice particles, with smaller amounts of rocky debris and dust. It also has numerous moons, including Titan, the second-largest moon in the Solar System.

Uranus and Neptune are known as ice giants. They have a larger proportion of 'ices' such as water, ammonia, and methane, compared to Jupiter and Saturn. Uranus is unique in that it rotates on its side relative to its orbit.

The Solar System formed 4.6 billion years ago from the gravitational collapse of a giant interstellar molecular cloud. Most of the system's mass is in the Sun, with most of the remaining mass contained in Jupiter.

Exploration of the Solar System has been carried out by robotic spacecraft and telescopes. Notable missions include the Voyager probes, which have traveled into interstellar space, and the Mars rovers, which continue to explore the Martian surface.

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